

AbiWord 2.4.6

www.abisource.com

AbiWord is a small, compact, free, open source word processing application that could well take the centre-stage for your word processing needs. It has nearly everything that both the novice and advanced user could ask for. For all its features, the setup file is just over 5MB, and if your primary work is with Word documents, then you might well consider switching from MS Word and OpenOffice.org.

The user interface is pretty much similar to what you would find in other applications in the same class, so there is not going to be any deep learning curve to get productive with this software. For non-English usage, the drawback could be the lack of support for Indian languages, but as an English word processor, this is a solid, dependable workhorse.

All the menus are laid out in a way that will seem familiar, so clicking on any will not spring any surprises or new, unfamiliar features. There are, of course, some nomenclature variations: Styles (in MS Word) is known as Stylist. The focus, it would seem, is to minimise the confusion for those transitioning from other word processors.

A unique feature you normally don't find in word processors is the use of plugins. There is a good collection of plugins that extends the functionality of AbiWord. These allow users to do things like select text from within the document and search for it online using Google; another plugin does the same thing for Wikipedia, and yet another translates selected pieces of text using the online translation site BabelFish.

The grammar and spell checkers may seem a bit primitive: many common words recognised by other word processors aren't there in AbiWord's dictionary. Also, the lack of a readability checker can be a source of discontent. However, the online Text Analyser at UsingEnglish.com's Web site